
“My men have sometimes failed to take a position, but to defend one, never!”

STATEMENT TO MAJOR HEROS VON BORCKE, DECEMBER 13, 1862

Widely regarded as the most inspired tactician of the Civil War, Thomas Jonathan Jackson lacked the showmanship frequently associated with heroic leaders of men. He was ungainly and introverted with an awkward and uncommunicative manner that often left people unimpressed. Yet he also possessed a total inner confidence that imposed itself upon subordinates.

An orphan raised by relatives in rural Virginia, Jackson had little formal education. As a result, he entered West Point at a disadvantage to other students. Through sheer hard work he graduated with creditable grades. When the U.S. went to war with Mexico in 1846, he won the admiration of his superiors as an artillery officer with courage and determination, sufficiently confident in his own judgment to refuse an order he considered wrong. However, when he was a professor at the Virginia Military Institute in the 1850s, his students found his manner and appearance ridiculous, his classes dull, and his punishments excessive.

A damned stone wall

Jackson chose to serve the Confederacy in April 1861 out of loyalty to his home state. He participated in enslavement, and had at least six enslaved people working for him. Given command of a Virginia brigade, he transformed its volunteers into a disciplined force, as demonstrated on the battlefield at First Bull Run. As his infantry stood firm on Henry House Hill, facing a Union onslaught, Confederate General Barnard E. Bee cried, “There stands Jackson